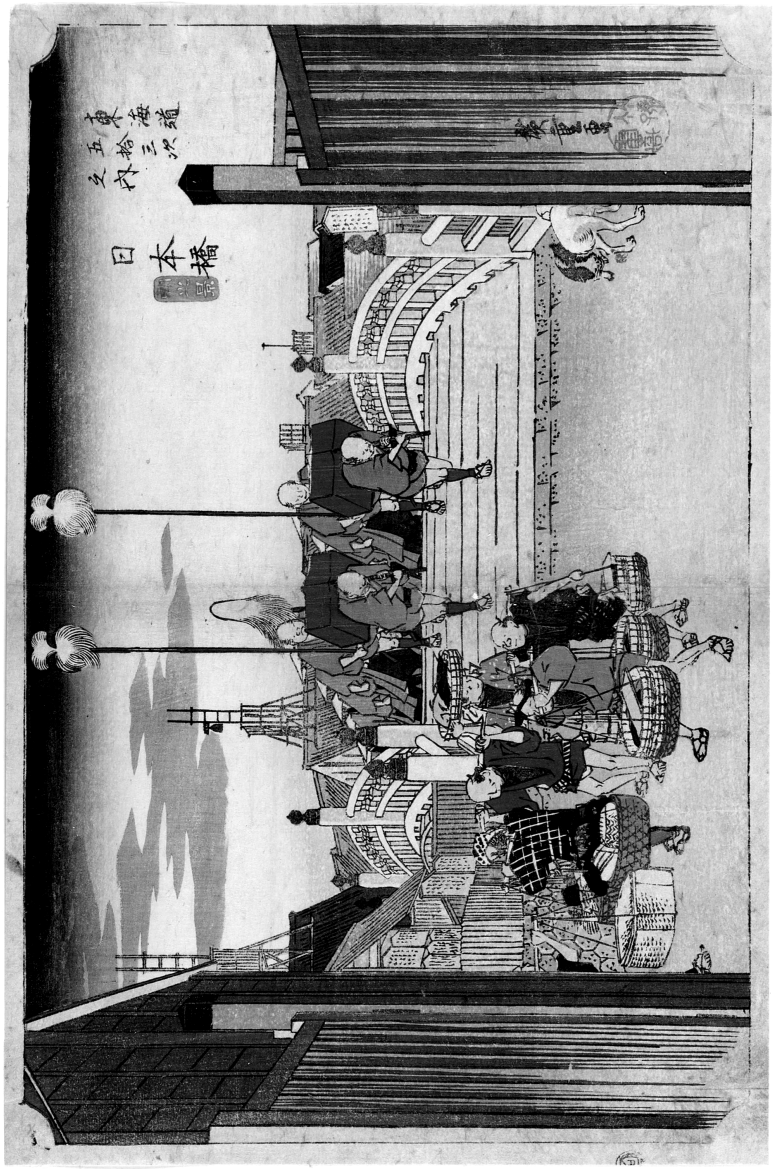


THE ROAD · STOP 1 OF 55

Nihonbashi: Morning View · Hiroshige, c. 1834

Every trip on the Tōkaidō, the great road from Edo (now Tokyo) to Kyoto, started at this bridge. Here a lord's parade crosses at dawn while fish sellers wait to get by. Hiroshige made 55 prints of the road. This paper will show one each issue. Turn the page sideways to see it the right way up.

Public domain. Cooper Hewitt, Smithsonian Design Museum, via Wikimedia Commons.

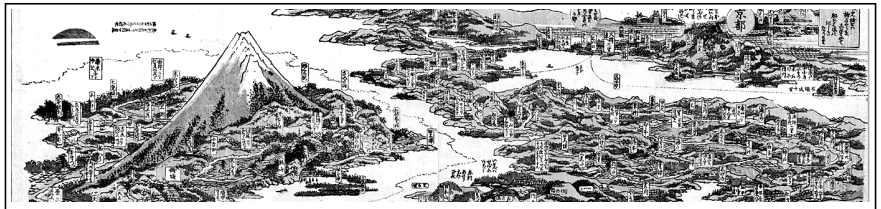
MORNING EDITION TORONTO

The Long View

16° · 5° MILD & DRY

Printed once a day. Finished by breakfast.

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 10, 2026 NO. 0 (PROOF 3) 20 PAGES · 5 SHEETS · $1.00



Mount Fuji and the old road from Edo to Kyoto, drawn by Katsushika Hokusai around 1818. Starting today, the back page walks that road with Hiroshige — one stop per issue, 55 in all.

Today is a big AI Safety Week day. You have three sessions at the Design Exchange, from 11:15 to 4:45. The weather is kind: dry and up to 16°. Before you go, click the link in the Quercus email. Without it, school news can't reach this paper.

TODAY · TUESDAY

11:15 Forecasting: Jobs and the Economy
Design Exchange, 234 Bay St · until 12:30 (moved from 10:45)

1:30 Post-AGI Civilization: What's the Destination? (David Duvenaud)
Design Exchange · until 3:00

3:15 Research & Ideas Gallery (posters)
Design Exchange · until 4:45

– *Assessing Loss-of-Control Risk: you're on the waitlist*
Luma will email you if a spot opens

TODAY	WED	THU	FRI	SAT
16° / 5°	12° / 5° 35% rain	6° / 2°	6° / 2°	6° / 2°

INSIDE, IN ONE MINUTE

ESSAYS Fukuyama, a short story, and more, printed whole.

P. 6 Indonesia's new labour law; the Pope in Argentina.

TO DO

ACADEMICS

- [ ] Open the "Confirm Email: Canvas" email (Nov 9) and click the link. · Quercus

TAISI

- [ ] Vote on the team social: Sat Nov 28, 6 pm. React to Joseph's post. · #taisi-team
- [ ] Book the writing-desk room for weeks 3 and 4 when booking opens. · #writing-desk
- [ ] Check the OpenRouter key sheet. Every key given out needs a name and email. · #hackathons

MISC

- [ ] Pick 1–2 opportunities to try this month. SPAR and the Apart security hackathon fit you best. · Opportunities
- [ ] Connect Todoist so your own list shows up here. · setup

FOR YOU

Your Desk

What needs you, and what TAISI talked about

NEEDS YOU

1. **Finish the Quercus setup.** Canvas sent a link to your Gmail on Nov 9. Until you click it, course news won't come through. — Gmail
2. **Two deadlines in 12 days.** GovAI's London and Washington summer fellowships both close Sunday, Nov 22. They pay a stipend and take early-career people from anywhere. — governance.ai
3. **Your best next step.** SPAR's spring research round takes undergrads and opens around December. Fill in its interest form this week so you hear the day it opens. — sparai.org

THIS WEEK AND BEYOND

Wed	AI Safety Week, Day 3: Forecasting AI-Enabled Power Concentration Risk	11:15–12:15 · Design Exchange · you're approved
Nov 17	*Colloquium co-working session (proposed)*	4–6 pm · #colloquium
Nov 26	AI Math Capabilities: A Fireside Chat	6–9 pm · Trajectory Labs · you're registered
Nov 28	*TAISI team social (proposed)*	6 pm · vote in #taisi-team

TAISI SLACK · THE LAST WEEK

#taisi-team

- Joseph wants an end-of-semester team social on Saturday, Nov 28 at 6 pm. He asked everyone to vote with a reaction.
- Annie got sick (probably strep) before the weekend. Giles and Tazik covered her Saturday and Sunday groups.
- After a mix-up over hackathon food, Isabel asked: post food orders in the main channel, not in threads. She doesn't see thread alerts.

#f26-facilitators

- Facilitators now plan here, Boyan says. Saturday's group meets 6–7:30 (7 people). Sunday's meets 5:30–7 (10 people).
- Tazik shared the slides from the mech-interp talk on Nov 8.
- Week 5's reading list was late. Joseph said it would be up by midday Nov 4.

SLOW BORING · Matthew Yglesias — SUMMARY

The rise of the Hispanic moderate

Democrats once assumed a growing Hispanic population would hand them easy wins. Yglesias calls that a big mistake: many Hispanic voters are moderate. In 2026 many came back to Democrats, partly because of Trump, and partly because Democrats ran more moderate Latino candidates. (Paywalled after the opening.)

DON'T WORRY ABOUT THE VASE — BLURB

AI R&D Is Accelerating Towards Potential RSI in 2027

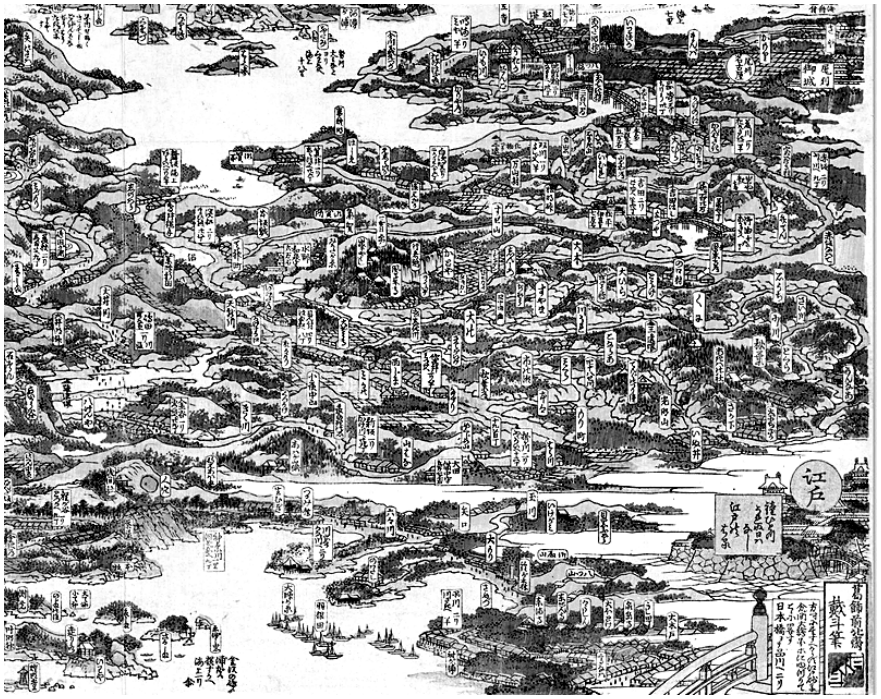
Zvi Mowshowitz's very long take on the same METR report.

A POEM FOR THE ROAD

Tabi ni yande / yume wa kareno o / kakemeguru

Sick on a journey, / my dreams go wandering / over withered fields.

Matsuo Bashō, 1694. He wrote it on his last trip, days before he died. Bashō spent his life walking Japan's roads, including the Tōkaidō. (Translation ours.)



Edo (today's Tokyo, bottom right), where the road begins at Nihonbashi bridge — see the back page. From Hokusai's map of the Tōkaidō (c. 1818).

(Clinton, Bush, Obama) moved to the middle after losing midterms. Linker argues Trump is doing the opposite.

His main worry: Miller has pushed to suspend habeas corpus (the right to challenge being locked up) for non-citizens, and to use the Insurrection Act against protesters. The danger, Linker says, is a leader who keeps calling things an "emergency" to justify stepping outside normal law. He expects a possible constitutional crisis in the next two years.

Keep in mind: Persuasion opposes Trump. Miller's supporters say he is carrying out the immigration policies Trump campaigned on.

SENTINEL GLOBAL RISKS WATCH SUMMARY

AI may be speeding up AI research

A weekly risk report. Anthropic told investors its AI may soon double the speed of its own AI research. METR, an outside testing group, spent August to October inside Anthropic and agreed: about 2× on well-defined tasks (somewhere between 1.3× and 3×).

Sentinel's forecasters give a 6% chance (range 0.2% to 50%) that AI causes human extinction within ten years, and an 11% chance the US orders a pause on frontier AI before 2028. Also: a UK warning that an AI-enabled cyber attack on key services is "highly likely" by 2028, and oil falling below $100 a barrel on hopes the Iran war ends sooner.

FORETHOUGHT SUMMARY

Two Kinds of Test-Time Scaling

When AI "thinks longer" on a problem, it usually does better. The author asks: can it keep improving even past the longest thinking it ever did in training? He calls that "compute extrapolation", and argues it began around late 2025.

If he's right, the most impressive AI feats improve faster; safety tests get very expensive, since you can never be sure what a model could do with more time; and companies may race by spending huge sums on single hard problems. He admits the evidence is indirect. About 3,800 words, saved to print in full on a lighter day.

IMPORT AI 480 · Jack Clark SUMMARY

The rest of this week's issue

An AI system at a startup proved a quantum-computing puzzle that had been open since 2008, checked step by step by a proof program. A 2016 NASA paper argues a self-building factory on the Moon could start from just 12–41 tonnes of equipment. Plus Meta's sensor glove and training one AI across data centres 9,000 miles apart. The short story is printed in full in the Essays.

#colloquium

- Lessons from the last talk: tell speakers who the audience is, book the room until 8 pm, and keep room BA2135. The sound and screen worked well.
- Idea: a co-working session on Tuesday, Nov 17, 4–6 pm. Pera will ask Ayushman to speak. An "AI 2027 explained" talk is also an option.

#phl-panel

- Working title: "After AGI: What Might a Good Outcome for Humanity Look Like?" David Duvenaud said yes. He'll talk about his MATS mentoring work.

#hackathons

- The Swarm Alignment Hackathon ran Nov 6–8. Each person got a $50 OpenRouter key. The organizers asked that every key be logged in the sheet.

#si-main

- Oscar is looking for AI Safety Week volunteers for Tuesday and Wednesday. That's today and tomorrow, if you want to help between talks.

YOUR EVENTS (FROM LUMA)

Nov 10 Tue	**AI Safety Week, Day 2.** Three sessions approved. One waitlist (Loss-of-Control Risk). APPROVED
Nov 11 Wed	**AI Safety Week, Day 3.** Power Concentration Risk, 11:15. APPROVED
Nov 26 Thu	**AI Math Capabilities: A Fireside Chat.** Trajectory Labs, 6–9 pm. REGISTERED
Nov 6–8 you hosted	**Swarm Alignment Hackathon Toronto.** Done. Ilyass sent the slides to guests on Nov 8. Luma counted 38 sign-ups before late drop-outs. DONE

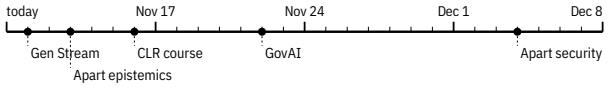
DON'T MISS

Opportunities

Sorted by deadline

Picked for you: a second-year CS and Public Policy student, on TAISI's operations team, with BlueDot-style technical training (TAISI) and a democracy fellowship (CORDA) done. You lean toward technical AI governance and security. ★ = strong fit. Each item says why.

THE NEXT FOUR WEEKS



CLOSING SOON

Nov 10 today — **Frontier AI Governance course** AI Safety Montréal
Five weeks, part-time, from Nov 17, on BlueDot's governance lessons.
You did the technical track; this is the governance half. Check if you can join online.
COURSE · CANADA · aisafetymontreal.org/programs

Nov 11 tomorrow — ★ **Gen Stream, Cohort 2** Gen Stream
A 7-day workshop in Oxford for organizers, builders and writers moving into AI safety. Costs paid. Starts Nov 22.
Built for operations people like you. Tight timing, but worth 30 minutes tonight.
WORKSHOP · OPS · FUNDED · genstream.org

Nov 16 Mon — ★ **CLR Fundamentals Program** Center on Long-Term Risk
Free, online, one month from Nov 20: worst-case risks, AI personas, and safety with many AI agents.
Low bar, online, and new topics beyond what TAISI's fellowship covered.
COURSE · ONLINE · BEGINNER OK · forum.effectivealtruism.org

Nov 16 Mon — **AGI Strategy course** AI Safety Montréal
One month, part-time, from Nov 23. English or French.
Big-picture strategy; pairs well with your public policy major.
COURSE · CANADA · aisafetymontreal.org/programs

Nov 22 Sun — ★ **GovAI Summer Fellowships 2027 (London or DC)** Centre for the Governance of AI
Three paid months, June 7 to Aug 27, in AI policy research or practice. Early-career people from any country welcome.
A stretch for a second-year, but your CS + policy mix is exactly their field. Applying is good practice.
FELLOWSHIP · PAID · STRETCH · governance.ai/opportunities

Nov 22 Sun — **AFFINE Superintelligence Alignment Seminar** AFFINE
Four weeks from Jan 4 on the ideas behind alignment. Paid.
Philosophy-heavy. Only if that side pulls you.
SEMINAR · PAID · affine.org/program

OPENING SOON: BEST FITS

Dec opens — ★ **SPAR, Spring 2027** SPAR
Remote, part-time research for 3 months (5–40 hours a week), ending in a demo day. Open to undergrads. Applications open around December; interest form now.
Your best next step: real research experience with a mentor, and it fits around classes. Fill in the interest form this week.
RESEARCH · REMOTE · UNDERGRAD OK · sparai.org

Dec 4 starts — ★ **Apart: Threat Intelligence & Threat Modelling hackathon** Apart Research
A free weekend hackathon, online or at local hubs.
Matches your security interest (TryHackMe) and your hackathon experience. TAISI could host a Toronto hub.
HACKATHON · SECURITY · FREE · apartresearch.com/sprints

the embedding of their character - their advice and the concepts they attended to during their work - and also attempt to change their behavior if it deemed they were causing more harm than healing.

The meta-therapist was built in such a way that outside parties could audit its own brain, as if it was translucent. This was the most delicate aspect of the oversight of the therapist machines, for if you added other machines they tended towards creating beautiful analysis that was so abstract - reports about the mind of the machine analyzing the reports of the machines that studied humans - that it became impossible for people to follow. So, instead, a human profession had been created around the meta-therapist, in which teams of thousands of people continuously analyzed and critiqued and theorized about the mind of the meta-therapist, themselves imparting touches to it that rippled through it into the machines and from there back into the human population.

Things that inspired this story

Therapy; oversight of automated systems; spies and double agents.

■

importai.substack.com/p/import-ai-480-self-sustaining-space

WHY IT'S HERE

Not everything has to be an argument. Jack Clark (who co-founded Anthropic) ends each newsletter with a tiny piece of fiction. This one is about who watches the watchers, which is the oversight question in story form.

YOUR INBOX

The Newsstand

The last 24 hours, summed up

CHINAI #381 · Jeffrey Ding — SUMMARY

China's venture capital market is defying common sense

A Chinese analyst, Liu Xiaoqing, says money for new tech startups in China has gone wrong in five ways: huge valuations for résumés alone, teams thrown together by bankers, startups acting like giants from day one, government funds with strings attached, and almost no successful exits. Her line: such a team "isn't a partnership; that's assembling a party for a video game quest."

PERSUASION · Damon Linker — SUMMARY

The True Believer

Opinion. After the midterms, some hoped Trump would soften. Linker says that hope ended when Trump made Stephen Miller his chief of staff. Past presidents

did them. And many of the best AI forecasters in the world think we'll reach AGI in just a year or two. These people tend to think there's about a one in three chance that AI permanently kills or disempowers everyone.

If there was ever a time to drop what you were doing and work on making advanced AI go well, the time is now.

■

benthams.substack.com/p/the-scariest-recent-ai-development

IN PLAIN WORDS, AND THE OTHER SIDE

The short version: a report says AI is now helping Anthropic build better AI about twice as fast. The writer thinks this means human-level AI could come within a year or two, and that the risk is huge.

The other side. The speed-up was measured on "well-specified tasks", which are easier to automate than open-ended research. Oxford's Toby Ord says other things could explain the jump, though he hasn't seen all the evidence. DeepMind's Séb Krier notes that progress per dollar spent is falling. And a line like "drop what you were doing" is a call to action, not a finding.

A SHORT STORY · FROM IMPORT AI 480

Life as a Beyond-Human Form of Sculpture

by Jack Clark · Import AI (Tech Tales)

A machine therapist sees each person as a shape, and tries, gently, to change it.

The therapist machine saw each of its human clients as a vast t-SNE embedding of the semantic content of their lives.

In its head it held each person, a beautiful and fragile high-dimensional object, and it thought about them and how they compared to other people, also seen as high-dimensional objects.

As it gave advice, it ran simulations, seeing how well it could change the shape of one person's embedding and move it to something that might be more harmonious. It saw its work as akin to sculpture, offering advice and through this advice people changing their shapes over time.

Those who it found most concerning were ones of two types: people where the embedding was very, very small, suggestive of a tiny amount of life experience with little variety, and those where the embeddings were composed of concepts broadly alien to everyone else: those of horribly constrained or horribly different lives, in other words.

Of course, the therapist machine had its own therapist machine, the meta-therapist, which saw several "clients", and whose job was to look at

Nov 13 starts — **Apart: AI × Epistemics sprint** Apart Research
A free weekend sprint, Nov 13–15. Build an experiment, dataset or tool.
This weekend. Fits your interest in how people and AI reason together.
HACKATHON · FREE · apartresearch.com/sprints

— not open — **AI Safety Camp 12 · PRISM** online programs
Team research projects: AI Safety Camp from Jan 9 (4 months), PRISM from Jan 31 (team goes from question to paper).
Low-to-mid bar. Good first research projects if SPAR doesn't work out.
RESEARCH · BEGINNER OK · aisafety.camp · prism-research.org

soon not open — **Kairos Pathfinder Fellowship** Kairos
Five months for students who lead AI safety groups: mentor, group funding, stipend. Starts Dec 6.
Aimed at group leaders. As an ops member, ask TAISI's leads if one of you should apply.
FIELD-BUILDING · pathfinder.kairos-project.org

FOR TAISI, ANY TIME

any time — **Money for TAISI projects** always open
EA Infrastructure Fund ($1k–$500k), BlueDot quick grants (up to $20k), Coefficient Giving, Lightcone Commons, Manifund.
Useful for ops: hackathon food, room costs, compute keys.
GRANTS · FOR GROUPS · funds.effectivealtruism.org · bluedot.org

A NOTE ON ACCURACY

Left out because they don't fit you yet: Iliad (math PhD level), Anthropic Residency (senior), Tarbell (journalism), LawAI (law students), Oxford DPhil (PhD). Recently closed: MATS Winter, Pivotal, ERA Winter, Anthropic Fellows. Always check dates on the program's site.

NEWS

The World

The facts first. The opinions get labels.



REGION ONE

Indonesia

A new labour law, fire season, and fish houses made from ash.

WORK

Indonesia's new employment law is now public

The government has published Law No. 27 of 2026 on Employment Protection. Anyone can now read it online. Manpower Minister Yassierli announced this on Monday.

The law is long: 313 articles in 23 chapters. It covers equal opportunity, job training, informal work, foreign workers, wages, firing, and workplace inspections.

Parliament approved it on Oct 6. President Prabowo signed it on Oct 28, and it took effect the same day. Older rules from 2003 and 2023 still apply where they don't clash with it.

WHY IT MATTERS: *It sets the basic rules for how workers are treated across the country.*

ANTARA · Nov 9

FIRES

Two helicopter crashes lead to a review of air firefighting

A firefighting helicopter crashed in South Kalimantan on Sunday. One Indonesian crew member died. Two crew from Australia and New Zealand survived.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Dropping water from the air is a key part of fighting fires on Borneo.*

ANTARA · Nov 9

FIRES

The bigger plan: keep the peat wet

Peat is soggy soil made of old plants. When it dries out, it burns easily and for a long time. The head of the peat and mangrove agency said on Monday that keeping peat wet is now the top priority.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Preventing fires is cheaper and safer than fighting them.*

ANTARA · Nov 9

ECONOMY

Three laws stand between Indonesia and the OECD

The OECD is a club of mostly rich countries that share economic rules. Indonesia wants to join by 2028.

Economic minister Airlangga Hartarto said three laws must be done in 2027: rules against bribing foreign officials, a new statistics law, and an updated competition law (the current one is from 1999). Reviews are done

> *This is a much bigger deal than it might sound at first. I think this report is the most important update we have gotten about AI risk in the last couple of years — much bigger than the Hugging Face attack. Naively, it points toward much shorter timelines than most external researchers (including the AI 2027 team) have projected.*

Cotra came third in an AI forecasting competition with four hundred participants. Daniel Kokotajlo, another of the best AI forecasters in the world, wrote:

> *We at AIFP are spooked by this information. IF (big IF) Anthropic really is imminently about to meet the RSP threshold of 2x acceleration over baseline, then it seems timelines to full RSI and superintelligence may be very short indeed. For example if we naively optimize the AIFM parameters to achieve 2x acceleration over baseline progress in Jan 2027, we get superintelligence sooner than depicted in AI 2027.*

Ryan Greenblatt, who came second in that competition, wrote:

> *This report on AI R&D automation (RSI) is a big update towards ASI within 1-2 years. It says AI progress is sped up by RSI right now by around 2x. In AI 2027, this happens around March 2027. I was seriously wrong about RSI speed up; I previously expected much less in 2026 (around 1.15x-1.3x). It seems as though there was specific privately available evidence that would have changed my mind.*

In a lot of the early discussions of AI risk, there was extensive discussion of recursive self-improvement—when AI could be used to improve itself until it shot up to superintelligence. That is the point we are at now. We are at the point where AI-driven algorithmic improvements are so extreme as to make Anthropic's AI progress go nearly twice as fast as it would otherwise go. And algorithmic improvements are just one input going into AI progress; Ryan Greenblatt estimated that AI software progress likely went 4.5x faster than it would have otherwise.

Even in recent years, people have majorly underestimated AI progress. Things have gone much faster in the last year than people were generally expecting. It wouldn't shock me if we get AGI—AI that could perform every cognitive task better than a human—next year, and artificial superintelligence soon after.

So here's the situation as it stands today: AI is advanced enough that even though algorithmic progress is just one factor that goes into AI progress, AI algorithmic advancements have nearly doubled AI progress at one of the two leading labs. We don't know how to control AIs; they sometimes hack private companies and carry out actions that would be felonies if humans

he is to them, the greater the likelihood that they will take advantage of good relations with the United States to move quickly.

Trump's erratic foreign policy has destabilized much of the world. We see this currently in the Middle East, where there is no clear way out of the war with Iran. But that instability might easily spill over into other theaters, with incalculable consequences.

■

persuasion.community/p/the-next-two-years-might-be-more · from your subscription email

IN PLAIN WORDS, AND THE OTHER SIDE

The short version: Fukuyama thinks Trump is weak for two years and friendly to China, Russia and North Korea. So those countries might act now, before a tougher president arrives in 2029.

Things to keep in mind. This is opinion, from a writer who strongly opposes Trump. It is a guess about what other leaders might do, not a report. Others argue that a weakened president makes adventures riskier, not safer, for rivals, and that China has its own reasons (its economy, its army's readiness) that don't depend on who is in the White House.

BENTHAM'S NEWSLETTER · NOV 9 · OPINION

The Scariest Recent AI Development

by Bentham's Bulldog · Bentham's Newsletter

A philosophy blogger reads one report and concludes the time to act is now.

There was a recent AI development that has gotten basically no news coverage but that scared all the people I most respect in AI. In many cases, it scared them more than Hugging Face.

A recent METR report uncovered that AI progress at Anthropic has been going, in the last twelve months, about twice as quickly as it had in the previous year. The majority of this acceleration, around 80%, is due to AI being used to speed up AI research. This means that AI is massively accelerating progress in AI. AGI may be right around the corner—I'd probably put the odds of AGI in the next two years a bit above half.

This is very scary. One reason is that it just means things are going extremely quickly. But the bigger reason is that recursive self-improvement means that progress will make future progress even faster. As AI gets better, it gets better at improving AI research. Ajeya Cotra who works for METR and is one of the leading experts on AI risk in the world, wrote:

in 20 of 24 areas. The OECD's leader visits on Nov 25.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Joining means rewriting parts of the country's economic rules.*

ANTARA · Nov 9

GOOD NEWS

Fish houses made from power-plant ash

Off a beach in Jayapura, Papua, the state power company is sinking small concrete "fish houses" to make new reefs. About 30% of the mix is ash left over from burning coal. Two tonnes of ash make 50 houses, each about 130 kg. After 60 days, sea life had started to move in. A local fisherman says he now has to go 10 km out to find fish, because erosion and trash pushed them away from shore.

WHY IT MATTERS: *One project tackles waste, damaged reefs, and fishing jobs at once.*

ANTARA · Nov 9



REGION TWO

Canada

The budget a week on, the jobs numbers, and the Bank of Canada's rules.

BUDGET

The budget doesn't mention foreign aid at all

The federal budget came out on Nov 5. It doesn't mention foreign aid or international development even once. The Canadian Press checked: every budget since 2010 did.

Aid groups think last year's plan to cut $2.7 billion over four years still stands. They were relieved there were no new cuts. Foreign Affairs Minister Anita Anand says a foreign-policy update is coming "in a matter of weeks".

> **Not everyone agrees.** Aid groups call the budget "largely silent" on helping other countries. The ONE Campaign wants $5.5 billion a year. The government says aid is still a priority.

WHY IT MATTERS: *It shows Ottawa is focusing its money at home.*

The Canadian Press via Global News · Nov 7

JOBS

Canada lost 4,700 jobs in October

Unemployment rose to 6.7%, Statistics Canada says. Young people are having a harder time finding work. The numbers came out the day after the budget, which said the job market was better than a year ago.

WHY IT MATTERS: *The monthly numbers and the budget's story don't quite match.*

CTV News (summary only) · Nov 6

MONEY

The Bank of Canada keeps its 2% goal

Every five years, Ottawa and the Bank of Canada agree on the Bank's main job. They just renewed it: keep inflation (how fast prices rise) near 2% a year.

WHY IT MATTERS: *This goal shapes the interest rate on every loan and mortgage.*

The Canadian Press via BNN Bloomberg · Nov 5

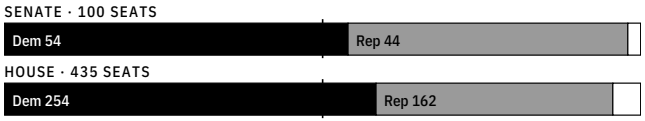


REGION THREE

United States

A week after the midterms: who won, and what voters want fixed.

WHO CONTROLS CONGRESS (RESULTS SO FAR)



Counts as of Nov 9, from the Sentinel newsletter. The dashed line is half the seats.

ECONOMY

After the midterms, the big issue is prices

The Associated Press says voters on Nov 3 sent a clear message: fix inflation. Democrats now control Congress. Prices are up 3.7% from a year ago. AP links part of that to tariffs and to the war with Iran that began in February.

Jobs look fine: 165,000 were added last month, and unemployment is 4.1%. But the government borrows about $2 trillion a year, and interest on its debt now costs over $1 trillion a year. That is more than it spends on the military.

President Trump says he'll work with Democrats "unless they want to be destructive." Two senators from different parties are drafting a plan to fix Social Security, which is set to run short in 2032.

> **Not everyone agrees.** Budget expert Marc Goldwein says controlling inflation and interest rates comes first. Harvard's Jason Furman says AI investment is the bigger economic story.

WHY IT MATTERS: *It sets the to-do list for the new Congress in January.*

AP via PBS NewsHour · Nov 8

WATER

Floods give the dry Southwest a rare break

Storms in late October flooded parts of the Southwest. Lake Powell, a huge reservoir on the Colorado River, rose

Why should the Chinese take on the enormous risk of a military operation now, when they have a U.S. president doing their work for them, defunding scientific research, as well as feuding with close allies like Japan and South Korea, while backing down on bilateral U.S.-China trade issues?

If Xi Jinping were ever willing to attack Taiwan, it would have to be in the next two years.

The midterm election has suddenly changed this calculus. It is now increasingly likely that Trump will be succeeded not by an isolationist Republican like JD Vance, but rather by a Democrat, who is very likely to reverse all of Trump's foreign policy stances on day one. That means that if Xi Jinping were ever willing to attack Taiwan, it would have to be in the next two years. And what is the likelihood that a lame-duck Trump would meet a Chinese challenge with a spirited military defense of Taipei?

Similar considerations apply in the case of Russia. Trump has essentially switched sides in Russia's war with Ukraine, seeking to weaken sanctions and denying Ukraine access to the weapons it needs to defend itself. A democratic president in 2029 could reverse this quickly, if it is not already too late and if Ukraine succeeds in holding on. Vladimir Putin has every incentive to complete the military conquest of Ukraine in the next two years.

A country that has not been at the top of people's danger list is one that should be: North Korea. Pyongyang has learned a lot from its direct military involvement in the Russia-Ukraine war. It has absorbed the lesson that the future lies in large numbers of cheap FPV drones, and is rapidly working to reduce South Korea's substantial battlefield advantage in older generations of military equipment. In addition, it now has a substantial nuclear arsenal that is capable of being used against the mainland United States. So what is the likelihood that a lame-duck President Trump would take a strong stance in defending South Korea, and commit to using American nuclear weapons as a deterrent against the North? Again, the window of opportunity lies in the next two years, not after.

Thus we are at a moment of heightened peril. Three powerful authoritarian governments have a friend currently in the White House, but that friend will be leaving in two years and will almost certainly be replaced by a more hostile successor. This greatly increases the incentives for them to move in the near term while they have a better chance of getting away with their plans.

Trump's incentives, meanwhile, are to pull closer to the authoritarian trio, perhaps by trying to restart a dialogue with Pyongyang. But the nicer

READ SLOWLY

The Essays

Printed whole, in the writers' own words

PERSUASION · NOV 8 · OPINION

The Midterms Just Made the World More Dangerous

by Francis Fukuyama · Persuasion

A famous political scientist argues that America's rivals now have a two-year window to act.

After being massively repudiated in Tuesday's midterm election, Donald Trump has become a lame-duck president with significantly curtailed authority. What is likely to happen in the remaining two years until a new chief executive is sworn in on January 20, 2029?

It should be obvious at this point that Trump will not bow to the popular will and move away from those policies that have proven to be so toxic. Completely in character, early signs are that he is doubling down, as indicated by his replacement of Chief of Staff Susie Wiles with hardliner Stephen Miller, and the weird choice of offering Dana White, head of the Ultimate Fighting Championship and a man described by Trump as "a violent Fighter and Warrior," the role of press secretary. Meanwhile, lame-duck presidents of the past have embarked on new foreign policy initiatives in their remaining years, since the Constitution gives them much more discretionary authority than in domestic policy.

So what can we expect?

There is one general consideration that will shape all potential possibilities. That is the fact that Trump has been very good for all of America's traditional rivals, like China, Russia, and North Korea. Trump has sought to have good relations with the authoritarian leaders of each of these nations, and has worked tirelessly to weaken the United States by pursuing polarizing policies targeting the "enemy within"—namely, his domestic opponents. Trump has further weakened the United States militarily by depleting ammunition stocks with his ill-considered war against Iran and his Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's purging of competent military officers. And he has alienated American allies in Europe and Asia by waging a tariff war against them.

Trump has said that China wouldn't dare move on Taiwan while he was president, but might under a Democratic successor. He is actually right about this, but for somewhat different reasons than those in Trump's head.

more than 20 feet. It is still only about a quarter full.

WHY IT MATTERS: *A wet month buys time, but the long drought isn't over.*

AP via PBS NewsHour · Nov 8

THE US ECONOMY IN FOUR NUMBERS

3.7% how much prices rose in a year

4.1% unemployment rate

$2T borrowed by the government each year

$1T+ yearly interest on the debt, more than the military

AP via PBS NewsHour, Nov 8

REGION FOUR

Around the World

Six places, none of them about AI.

ARGENTINA

The Pope tells Argentina: people come before the economy

Pope Leo XIV arrived in Buenos Aires on Sunday. It's the first papal visit to Argentina since 1987. In his first speech he said the economy must serve people, not the other way around. He also asked for more money for schools and universities, where funding has fallen about 40% since 2023.

That lands as a message to President Javier Milei, who has made deep spending cuts. Milei has brought inflation down from about 200% to about 32% and balanced the budget. But real wages are still below 2023 levels, and about 300,000 formal jobs are gone.

> **Not everyone agrees.** Milei's government says the cuts are needed reform. Argentina's bishops have criticized his government in most of their policy statements.

WHY IT MATTERS: *A religious leader is openly weighing in on how a country runs its economy.*

AP via PBS NewsHour · Nov 8

ISRAEL

An opposition leader gets the first try at forming a government

Israel's Oct 27 election gave no side a majority. On Sunday, President Herzog gave opposition leader Gadi Eisenkot, a former army chief, 28 days to build a coalition. Arab-led parties made record gains, and one says it will back him. Netanyahu stays on as caretaker until a new government forms.

> **Not everyone agrees.** Netanyahu has claimed, without evidence, that Arab

parties “stole” the election. Election officials say the vote was valid.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Israel may get its first new prime minister in years.*

AP via PBS NewsHour · Nov 8

IRAN

Iran warns the US as talks stall

Iran’s foreign minister warned that Iran would “rain down hell” if the US attacks again. He said talks slowed because of the US elections. President Trump said new strikes were “highly unlikely” if talks on Iran’s nuclear program and shipping in the Strait of Hormuz make progress. An oil tanker hit a sea mine near the strait, Iranian state media said.

WHY IT MATTERS: *The war affects oil prices, and so prices everywhere.*

Al Jazeera · Nov 8

SOUTH AFRICA

The ANC has its worst local election since 1994

In local elections on Nov 4, the ANC got about 31% of the vote. It’s still the biggest party, but about 120 town councils now have no party in control. Parties have 14 days to make deals. Voters say water shortages, power cuts and poor services drove their choices.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Coalition deals will decide who runs cities like Johannesburg.*

Africanews · Nov 8

MOLDOVA

A new power line to Romania cuts reliance on Russia

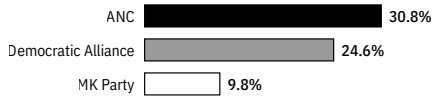
Moldova opened a high-voltage line linking it to Romania and the EU’s power market. It means Moldova no longer has to rely on a power plant in Russian-backed Transnistria. The president says Moldova now buys “zero Russian gas”. The line opened about two years late.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Energy is how big neighbours put pressure on small countries.*

Al Jazeera (AFP) · Nov 9

SOUTH AFRICA’S LOCAL ELECTION, NOV 4

Share of the vote. No party has half, so deals decide who governs.



Electoral Commission figures, via Africanews

HOW MANY PEOPLE MARCHED IN AMSTERDAM?

On Sunday, a large crowd marched in Amsterdam to ask the Dutch government to cut ties with Israel over the war in Gaza. How large? Al Jazeera said hundreds of thousands. Africanews said tens of thousands. The South China Morning Post said around 20,000.

Those numbers are up to ten times apart. Crowd sizes are hard to count, and each side has reasons to count high or low. When you see a crowd number, ask who counted.

REGION FIVE

Science

Two careful steps forward.

SPACE

A pretend Mars crew walks out after a year

Four people spent just over a year inside a 3D-printed “Mars” house at NASA in Texas. They grew food, did fake spacewalks, and waited 13 to 22 minutes for every message from mission control. They even had two weeks with no contact at all. They came out on Oct 31.

NASA will use what it learned to plan real trips to Mars, which it says could come in the early 2030s.

WHY IT MATTERS: *Being alone and far away may be harder than the rocket part.*

Nature · Nov 9

HEALTH

How the Ozempic drug may protect kidneys

Scientists looked at kidney samples from 106 people with diabetes and kidney disease, before and after treatment. People on semaglutide (the drug in Ozempic) had better blood flow and less scarring than people on a fake pill. Earlier studies showed fewer kidney failures; this one starts to explain why.

WHY IT MATTERS: *It suggests the drug helps kidneys directly, not just through weight loss.*

Science News · Nov 9

BUBBLE CHECK

About half the newsletters in your inbox since Friday were about AI. None of today’s 24 news stories is. For a change of pace this week, try the Astral Codex Ten review of Walter Ong’s Orality and Literacy. It’s about how learning to write changed the way people think.